

Unnecessary Circumcision

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In many hospitals, circumcision has become a routine part of the care provided for male infants. This author contends that it is time for the medical establishment to rethink both the reasons for and the consequences of this procedure.

In recent years, the debate on circumcision has been conducted on a relatively low plane, with proponents arguing that circumcision may prevent some unusual or rare conditions. Opponents of circumcision argue that it has no medical benefits. This article seeks to simplify the subject and raise it to a higher plane—focusing on the positive value of the intact foreskin.

Physiology

Before birth, the glans penis is covered with skin. This skin is not loosely attached; indeed, it is as tightly attached to the glans as is the skin on the hand, for example.¹

At approximately 17 weeks' gestation, cells in the area of separation between the future foreskin and the glans initiate the process of creating the preputial space (ie, the space between the glans penis and the intact foreskin). They begin to form microscopic balls comprising multiple layers of cells. As these whorls of cells enlarge, cells at the center are cut off from nutrients; they die and create a space. These minute spaces coalesce, eventually becoming the preputial space.¹ This process is completed by age 3 in 90% of boys, but it may take as long as 17 years for some boys to have a fully retractable foreskin.

At birth, the separation of the foreskin from the glans has just begun. The newborn's penis is, of

course, not yet fully developed. Not only does circumcision interfere with its development, but it requires that the surgeon tear the skin from the sensitive glans to permit removal. Perhaps as a way to avoid confronting this reality, physicians refer to this as "breaking adhesions."

Function

If physicians would simply leave the newborn's penis intact, as Dr Spock came to recommend,² the foreskin would be left to fulfill its several functions. In infancy, the foreskin protects the glans from irritation and from fecal material. The function of the foreskin in adulthood may at first seem more obscure. The shaft and usually the glans of an uncircumcised man's penis are covered by skin. Retracting the foreskin reveals the glans and makes the skin on the shaft somewhat loose. Of what use is this redundant skin? During erection, the penile shaft elongates, becoming about 50% longer. The foreskin covers this lengthened shaft and is thus specifically designed to accommodate an organ that is capable of a marked increase in diameter and length.

In addition, the foreskin is one of the most sensitive parts of the penis and can enhance the quality of sexual intercourse. Anatomical studies demonstrate that the foreskin has a greater concentration of complex nerve endings than the glans.³ If there is any